

Ten months on in Taupō

Hearing from our leaders

At the end of July, I will have been in the general manager role for 10 months.

There has been a lot going on over that time. For me, it has been about learning about the community - in the community and from the community.

I have also been learning about the one service, two sites model and working in partnership with the overarching service managers, senior leaders and our clinicians.



General Manager Taupō Hospital
Ngaire Buchanan

Taking on the Taupō Emergency Department management on a temporary basis has added to my understanding of how everything works here.

Planning for a growing community

The Taupō and Tūrangi population is currently 42,700 and is forecast to grow to approximately 67,400 by 2060. Five years ago, the population was approximately 28,000. The growth rate in 2024/25 was 1.2 per cent higher than the national average, and our Māori population is currently 31 per cent. As Taupō is a tourist destination, our population can double to around 80,000 during peak seasons and major events.

This means we need to work collaboratively and plan carefully to continue providing appropriate care for our community. It is not simply about building more; we must also think creatively about how we can provide services differently across the patient population.

Working together

We cannot do this alone. Taupō Hospital has strong community connections, with hospital representatives participating in local leadership groups, including the Taupō and Tūrangi Leadership Groups and the Regional Clinical Rural Network, which links to the National Clinical Rural Network. Membership across these groups includes primary health care, iwi, the Iwi Māori Partnership Board, planning and secondary services.

These groups provide opportunities to work in partnership on rural generalist pathways, cross-professional workforce planning and population outcomes.

Growing local capability

Within Taupō and Tūrangi, we are developing endoscopy training for rural generalists. Taupō has recently secured training funding, and we are strengthening our resident medical officer workforce. Our innovative approach has also seen specialists working in partnership with iwi to run marae-based outreach clinics.

We are delighted that Taupō has recently been successful in gaining fifth-year medical students through the University of Auckland's Rural Medical Immersion Programme. This provides a year of training across both primary and secondary care.

Closer to home, the hospital has celebrated its first official nurse practitioner. We are very proud of home-grown Emergency Department nurse Hailey Holmes, and a second senior nurse, Jason Tillman, is close to achieving his registration in New Zealand.

Care closer to home

The outpatient project, which aims to bring care closer to home for residents, is well underway, with multiple new outpatient appointments being delivered on site. The next stage is to increase our telemedicine capabilities on site and then extend them into patients' homes.

Surgical services have been ensuring our operating theatre is up to date and ready for increased services on site. Over the next six months, I am charged with having the theatre used for 10 half-days each week for surgery or endoscopy.

Clinical governance on site has been strengthened, recruitment has improved, and we now have a designated person providing liaison between Rotorua and Taupō.

The latest programme of work is our strategy for the Taupō Inpatient Unit, which will enable more Taupō patients to receive acute care locally.

We are working with the Lakes Integrated Community Health Service team to introduce Hospital in the Home. This will increase our capacity to accommodate patients requiring care in the Taupō Inpatient Unit and reduce transfers to Rotorua, except where specialist care is needed.

Looking ahead

With all these initiatives underway, it is an exciting time. This is a team effort with one goal in mind: providing patients and their whānau with the best, most appropriate and safest care, as close to home as possible.

I am certainly looking forward to the next year with our teams and communities.

Ngaire Buchanan
General Manager, Taupō Hospital